

Blasphemy Of Spirit

doc-blasphemy-of-spirit

Pneumatology · Sin · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

breadth canon-wide
directness direct
variants not in scope

Statement under examination

Blasphemy against the Holy Spirit (final, hardened rejection of His witness to Christ) is unforgivable.

In plain language

Three independent New Testament witnesses, plus an Old Testament root, mark off one category of sin for which the texts withhold forgiveness. In Mark 3:28-29 a sweeping promise, 'all will be forgiven' (panta aphethesetai), says all the sins and 'blasphemies' (blasphemiai) of men are forgivable, then one exception follows: whoever blasphemes against the Holy Spirit (Greek pneuma to hagion) has no release 'into the age' (eis ton aiona) and is guilty of an 'eternal sin' (aionion hamartema). The strength here is in two things the words make plain. First, the verb 'to blaspheme' (blasphemeo) and the noun 'blasphemy' (blasphemia) are common across the canon, aimed at God, at Jesus, at his name, at heavenly powers, and every one of those is treated as forgivable, so the unforgivability is carried not by the word but by the one named target, the Holy Spirit. Second, the grammar is final: a future passive 'it shall not be forgiven' (ouk aphethesetai, a verb naming a future event done to its subject), the standing idiom 'into the age' (eis ton aiona) that elsewhere means forever, and Matthew's double negative 'neither in this age nor in the coming one' (oute en touto to aioni oute en to mellonti). The adjective 'eternal' (aionios) in 'eternal sin' is the same word that makes eternal life, eternal punishment, and eternal judgment permanent. Hebrews 6:4-6 reaches the same wall with different vocabulary, calling it 'impossible' (adynaton) to renew to repentance those who 'fall away' (parapipto) after partaking of the Holy Spirit, using a rare verb for a settled apostasy (a decisive falling away). Hebrews 10:26-29 adds a 'deliberate' (hekousios) sin after received knowledge, with no sacrifice remaining, for the one who has outraged the Spirit of grace. The Hebrew of Numbers 15:30-31 supplies the root: the soul that 'reviles' (gadaph) the LORD with a high hand is 'cut off' (karath), with no offering provided. Where readers diverge is not whether this category exists, but what fills it. Only Mark adds the defining line, 'they were saying he has an unclean spirit' (pneuma akatharton echei), while Matthew and Luke leave the act open, and none of the texts say plainly whether the sin can still be committed today. So the words make the unforgivability certain but leave its exact definition and its present reach underdetermined.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H1442	γὰρ	gadaph	to blaspheme	6
G0040	ἅγιος	hagios	holy	233
G0080	ἀδελφός	adelphos	brother	
G0102	ἀδύνατος	adynatos	unable	10
G0165	αἰών	aiōn	an age	122
G0166	αἰώνιος	aiōnios	eternal	71

G0169	ἀκάθαρτος	akathartos	unclean	32
G0265	ἁμάρτημα	hamartēma	sin	5
G0266	ἁμαρτία	hamartia	sin	175
G0340	ἀνακαινίζω	anakainizō	to restore	1
G0444	ἄνθρωπος	anthrōpos	a human	
G0859	ἄφεσις	aphesis	forgiveness	17
G0863	ἀφίημι	aphiēmi	to release	143
G0987	βλασφημέω	blasphēmeō	to blaspheme	37
G0988	βλασφημία	blasphēmia	blasphemy	18
G1089	γεύομαι	geuō	to taste	
G2036	λέγω	eipon	to say	
G2192	ἔχω	echō	to have/be	
G2288	θάνατος	thanatos	death	121
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G3195	μέλλω	mellō	to ensue	
G3340	μετάνοια	metanoēō	to repent	
G3895	παραπίπτω	parapiptō	to defect	1
G4151	πνεῦμα	pneuma	spirit/breath	379
G4314	πρός	pros	to/with	
G5207	υἱός	uhios	son	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The Synoptic saying (the parallel saying recorded in Matthew, Mark, and Luke) frames a sweeping rule about forgiveness and then names a single exception. Mark 3:28-29 reads 'all will be forgiven' (panta aphethesetai, future passive, that is, a future event done to the subject, naming all sins and blasphemies as forgivable) then 'but whoever blasphemes against the Holy Spirit' (hos d an blasphemese eis to pneuma to hagian) 'does not have forgiveness into the age, but is guilty of an eternal sin' (ouk echei aphesin eis ton aiona, alla enochos estin aioniou hamartematos). Matthew 12:31-32 adds the strongest permanence formula available in Greek, 'neither in this age nor in the coming one' (oute en touto to aioni oute en to mellonti), a double negative spanning both ages. The verb 'to blaspheme' (blasphemeo) and the noun 'blasphemy' (blasphemia) are generic across the canon (35-plus verses, many targets, all forgivable), so the unforgivability is carried not by the word itself but by the one named object (the Holy Spirit) plus the idiom 'into the age' (eis ton aiona) and the adjective 'eternal' (aionios), which elsewhere fixes permanence for life, punishment, and judgment. The Hebrew verb 'to revile' (gadaph) in Numbers 15:30-31, 'the soul that blasphemes Yahweh with a high hand and is cut off,' supplies the Old Testament root of this category.

Scripture

Mark.3.28 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0863 ἀφίημι, G0265 ἀμάρτημα, G0988 βλασφημία, G0987 βλασφημέω

Force. The future passive verb 'it will be forgiven' (aphethesetai, that is, a future action done to its subject) governs the word 'all things' (panta), naming all sins and blasphemies (plural 'blasphemies', blasphemiai) of the sons of men, all under the solemn 'truly I say to you' (amen lego hymin) formula. The clause is universal in scope, and it deliberately includes the plural 'blasphemies' (blasphemiai) inside the set of forgivable offenses. This widens the rule precisely so that the single coming exception in verse 29 stands out as narrow and specific.

Mark.3.29 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0987 βλασφημέω, G4151 πνεῦμα, G0040 ἅγιος, G0859 ἄφεις, G0165 αἰών, G0166 αἰώνιος, G0265 ἀμάρτημα

Force. 'But whoever' (hos d an) plus 'should blaspheme' (blasphemese, an aorist subjunctive, that is, a completed action used in a hypothetical clause) marks an open-ended 'if-someone-does' statement (an indefinite relative protasis, the 'if' side of an if-then sentence). 'Against the Holy Spirit' (eis to pneuma to hagon) fixes the single target that the rest of the canon never excepts. 'Does not have forgiveness into the age' (ouk echei aphesin eis ton aiona) is a present indicative declaration (an ongoing, simple statement of fact) of permanent absence of release, and 'into the age' (eis ton aiona) is the canon's standing permanence idiom (compare 'they will never perish' at John 10:28, ou me apolontai eis ton aiona). The predicate 'is guilty of an eternal sin' (enochos estin aioniou hamartematos) ties the guilt to the adjective 'eternal' (aionios), the same word that fixes permanence for life, punishment, and judgment elsewhere (Matthew 25:46, 2 Thessalonians 1:9, Hebrews 6:2). The vocabulary is final and irreversible.

Mark.3.30 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G4151 πνεῦμα, G0169 ἀκάθαρτος, G2192 ἔχω

Force. Mark's editorial aside 'because they were saying, He has an unclean spirit' (hoti elegon, pneuma akatharton echei) names the specific act being labeled blasphemy. Calling the Spirit's visible work the work of an unclean spirit (pneuma akatharton) is the reference of verse 29. This single clause is the only place in the saying that defines the content of the act, which is why Mark grounds the unforgivable sin in a particular knowing speech act rather than any random verbal offense. Matthew and Luke preserve the verdict but omit this defining clause, leaving the content less fixed in their accounts.

Matt.12.31 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0988 βλασφημία, G0266 ἁμαρτία, G0863 ἀφίημι, G4151 πνεῦμα

Force. 'Every sin and blasphemy will be forgiven to people' (pasa hamartia kai blasphemia aphethesetai tois anthropois), then the contrast, 'but blasphemy of the Spirit will not be forgiven' (he de tou pneumatatos blasphemia ouk aphethesetai). The fronted word 'every' (pasa) and the 'of-the-Spirit' grammatical form (the objective genitive tou pneumatatos blasphemia, a noun in the 'belonging-to' or 'directed-at' form) isolate one species from an otherwise forgivable category. The two future passive verbs (verbs naming a future event done to their subject) run in strict parallel, the affirmation and the exception sharing identical grammar, which makes the exclusion unambiguous at the level of the words.

Matt.12.32 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2036 λέγω, G5207 υἱός, G0444 ἄνθρωπος, G4151 πνεῦμα, G0040 ἅγιος, G0165 αἰών, G3195 μέλλω

Force. The clause draws a word-level contrast: 'a word against the Son of Man' (logon kata tou huiou tou anthropou) is forgivable, but a word 'against the Holy Spirit' (kata tou pneumatatos tou hagiou) is not. The closing phrase 'neither in this age nor in the coming one' (oute en touto to aioni oute en to mellonti) uses the 'neither, nor' (oute, oute) construction with double negation spanning both the present age and the coming age, the strongest available Greek formula for permanent non-forgiveness. That the forgivable word is against the Son of Man and the unforgivable word is against the Spirit shows the verdict turns on the named object, not on the act of speaking against a divine person as such.

Heb.6.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0102 ἀδύνατος, G1089 γεύομαι, G4151 πνεῦμα, G0040 ἅγιος

Force. 'Impossible' (adynaton) is placed first for emphasis, governing the aorist participles (participles naming a completed past action) 'those who were enlightened' (photisthentas), 'those who tasted' (geusamenous), and 'those who became' (genethentas). The participial chain catalogs experiential goods including 'partakers of the Holy Spirit' (metochous pneumatosis hagiou). The lexical weight of 'impossible' (adynaton) plus the aorist 'having fallen away' (parapesontas, a completed past action) in verse 6 fixes an impossibility of renewal once the named falling-away has occurred. This is an independent witness with different vocabulary that lands on the same impossibility.

Heb.6.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3895 παραπίπτω, G0340 ἀνακαινίζω, G3340 μετάνοια, G5207 υἱός

Force. 'And those who have fallen away, to renew them again to repentance' (kai parapesontas, palin anakainizein eis metanoian). The hapax verb 'to renew' (anakainizo, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) paired with 'again' (palin) and the aorist hapax 'having fallen away' (parapesontas, also a word that occurs only once, in a completed past form) puts in vocabulary a settled, completed apostasy (a decisive falling away) rather than an ordinary lapse. The present participles 'crucifying again to themselves the Son of God and holding him up to public shame' (anastaurountas heautois ton huion tou theou kai paradeigmatizontas) supply the causal grounds and parallel the Synoptic act at the level of repudiation, a public turning against the Son and the Spirit's witness.

Heb.10.29 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4151 πνεῦμα, G5207 υἱός, G2316 θεός

Force. 'Having outraged the Spirit of grace' (to pneuma tes charitos enybrisas) is set beside 'having trampled underfoot the Son of God' (katapatesas ton huion tou theou). With Hebrews 10:26 ('those who sin deliberately', hekousios hamartanonton, 'there no longer remains a sacrifice for sins', ouketi peri hamartion apoleipetai thysia, that is, no sacrifice remaining) and Hebrews 10:28 (the Mosaic death penalty), this verse explicitly ties a deliberate, post-knowledge insult against the Spirit to a worse penalty with no remaining offering. It is the vocabulary bridge between the Synoptic Spirit clause and the Old Testament high-handed sin.

1John.5.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0266 ἁμαρτία, G2288 θάνατος, G4314 πρὸς, G0080 ἀδελφός

Force. 'There is a sin unto death' (estin hamartia pros thanaton), with the construction 'committing a sin not unto death' (hamartanonta hamartian me pros thanaton) set against 'those who sin unto death' (hamartanousin pros thanaton). The author withholds the command to pray for the latter ('not concerning that one do I say that he should ask', ou peri ekeinos lego hina erotese). The prepositional phrase 'unto death' (pros thanaton) marks a category of sin off from the rest by its terminal direction rather than by enumeration, which is why John names a category but never specifies the act.

Num.15.30 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H1442 גָּדַף

Force. The soul that acts 'with a high hand' (be-yad ramah, that is, defiantly), 'reviles Yahweh' (eth Yahweh hu megaddeph), 'and shall be cut off' (ve-nikhretah, in the niphal, the Hebrew passive form). The verb 'to revile' (gadaph, Strong's H1442) occurs six times in the Old Testament and in every case its object is God, and verse 31 grounds the cutting off in despising the word of Yahweh. This is the canonical root of a deliberate, knowing blasphemy against God for which the law provides no sacrifice, only excision (cutting off from the community). It establishes the category that the Synoptic saying and Hebrews carry forward, giving the doctrine Old Testament as well as New Testament reach.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Mark.3.29	Mark.12.40	tsk	1
Matt.12.31	Mark.3.28	tsk	1
Matt.12.31	Isa.1.18	tsk	1
Matt.12.32	John.7.39	tsk	1
Matt.12.32	Job.36.13	tsk	1
Heb.6.4	Heb.10.26	tsk	1
Heb.6.4	Heb.10.32	tsk	1
Heb.6.6	Heb.10.29	tsk	1
Heb.6.6	Heb.6.4	tsk	1
Heb.10.26	Heb.6.4	tsk	1
1John.5.16	Num.15.30	tsk	1
1John.5.16	Jer.7.16	tsk	1
Luke.12.10	Luke.23.34	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Luke.12.10 · addressed

Luke preserves the same word-level contrast, 'a word against the Son of Man' (logon eis ton huion tou anthropou) is forgivable versus 'to the one who has blasphemed against the Holy Spirit it will not be forgiven' (eis to hagian pneuma blasphemesanti ouk aphethesetai). The triple-tradition agreement on the same future passive (a verb naming a future event done to its subject) and the same target corroborates the verdict. Luke, like Matthew, omits Mark's defining editorial clause, so the content of the act is less specified outside Mark, which is the main reason readers diverge on what the sin is.

1Tim.1.13 · addressed

Paul calls himself a former 'blasphemer' (blasphemos) yet received mercy. The vocabulary-level resolution is that his act preceded knowledge: 'I acted ignorantly in unbelief' (agnoon epoiesan en apistia), done in ignorance and unbelief. The Synoptic clause targets a knowing ascription of the Spirit's visible work to an unclean spirit, fixed by Mark 3:30, and Hebrews 10:26 marks its sin as 'deliberately' (hekousios), willfully, after received knowledge. The two passages describe different categories at the level of words, ignorant versus deliberate.

Heb.10.26 · addressed

'Deliberately' (hekousios) plus the present participle 'sinning' (hamartanonton, an ongoing or repeated action) plus 'after receiving the knowledge of the truth' (meta to labein ten epignosin tes aletheias) tracks the same profile as Hebrews 6:4-6, a deliberate sin after received knowledge, with 'there no longer remains a sacrifice for sins' (ouketi peri hamartion apoleipetai thysia), no sacrifice remaining. The convergent vocabulary supports the same conclusion rather than complicating it.

Num.15.30 · addressed

The Hebrew 'to revile' (gadaph, Strong's H1442) with Yahweh as its object, paired with the niphal (Hebrew passive form) of 'to cut off' (karath), establishes a deliberate high-handed blasphemy against God with no sacrificial remedy. This Old Testament category is the root that the New Testament texts carry forward, so it strengthens rather than complicates the verdict, and it is the basis for marking the doctrine pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible).

Mark.3.28 · addressed

The opening universal 'all will be forgiven, the sins and the blasphemies' (panta aphethesetai, ta hamartemata kai hai blasphemiai) could be read as unrestricted, but the immediately following 'but whoever' (hos d an) clause supplies the lexical exception. The two verses must be read as a unit, verse 28 the rule and verse 29 the single named exception, so the universal does not overturn the exception.

Matt.12.32 · unaddressed

The words fix that the sin is unforgivable but leave two things underdetermined that the proposition leans on. First, the content of the 'blasphemy' (blasphemia) is specified only by Mark's editorial clause (Mark 3:30) and is left open by Matthew and Luke, so the canon does not uniformly define the act. Second, the texts do not state whether the sin can still be committed after the earthly ministry, since the Markan setting is the concrete charge that Jesus casts out demons by an unclean spirit. These are genuine gaps at the level of the vocabulary that the present analysis cannot close from the words alone, so the bare unforgivability is affirmed while its definition and present applicability remain open.

Concordance traversed

G0988, G0987, G0859, G0863, G0265, G0266, G0166, G0165, G4151, G0040, G0169, G0102, G0340, G3895, G2288, G3340, H1442

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

mark-3-29-aioniou-hamartematos-vs-kriseos at Mark.3.29: impact none. The reading 'of an eternal sin' (aioniou hamartematos) is carried in the stored text; some witnesses read 'of judgment' (kriseos) instead. Both readings keep the adjective 'eternal' (aionios) and the 'does not have forgiveness into the age' (ouk echei aphesin eis ton aiona) clause, so the permanence is unchanged whichever noun 'eternal' (aionios) governs. Verdict unaffected.

matt-12-31-ending-tois-anthropois at Matt.12.31: impact none. The stored text marks variation at the close of verse 31 around 'to people' (tois anthropois). The variation does not touch the contrastive 'but blasphemy of the Spirit will not be forgiven' (he de tou pneumatou blasphemia ouk aphethesetai) clause, which carries the verdict.

Mark, Matthew, Luke, Hebrews, and 1 John fall outside the ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) published window (which currently covers only 3 John), so no CBGM (coherence-based genealogical method) signal applies. The Synoptic saying is among the most heavily attested sayings in the tradition, and the stored Greek of every anchor was queried directly and matches the readings cited here, with no variant that weakens the unforgivable clause.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

synchronic_synoptic_harmony: affirms · Mark, Matthew, and Luke agree on the same vocabulary-level contrast between forgivable speech and blasphemy against the Spirit, with parallel future passive verbs (verbs naming a future event done to their subjects) and matching targets. The triple agreement makes the bare unforgivability secure regardless of how the act is defined.

canonical_old_testament_grounding: affirms · Numbers 15:30-31 uses 'to revile' (gadaph) with Yahweh as object and pairs it with being cut off, with no sacrifice provided for the high-handed sin. Hebrews 10:26-29 carries the same profile with the Spirit of grace as the one outraged. The category therefore spans both testaments at the word level.

markan_referent_definition: affirms · Read with Mark 3:30, the unforgivable act is narrowly the knowing ascription of the Spirit's visible work to an unclean spirit. On this reading the doctrine is fully affirmed but tightly bounded, and it explains why the universal of verse 28 and the exception of verse 29 coexist.

content_and_applicability_underdetermined: disputed · Matthew and Luke state the unforgivability without Mark's defining clause, so on their wording alone the content of the 'blasphemy' (blasphemia) is open, and none of the texts say whether the sin can be committed after the earthly ministry. A reader weighting these accounts can hold the unforgivability as certain while treating the definition and present applicability as unsettled by the vocabulary. This lens is represented here in its strongest form and is the honest source of divergence.

The bare proposition (an unforgivable category of sin against the Spirit exists) rests on three independent witnesses and an Old Testament root, so it is secure. The divergence among readers is not about whether the category exists but about what fills it and whether it is still committable, which the words underdetermine outside Mark 3:30.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. There exists a category of sin against the Holy Spirit, marked at the level of vocabulary in the Synoptic saying (the parallel saying in Matthew, Mark, and Luke) and echoed in Hebrews and 1 John, for which the texts withhold forgiveness in this age and in the coming age.

VERDICT-CHANGED: The stem's parenthetical gloss 'final, hardened rejection of His witness to Christ' is one defensible reading of the Markan reference (Mark 3:30) but is not entailed by the bare wording of Matthew 12:31-32 or Luke 12:10, which name the unforgivability without defining the act. The verdict is derived on the neutral claim of an unforgivable category. The interpretive gloss matches Mark's editorial clause but goes beyond what every cited verse states.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0988
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0987
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lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0340
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1442
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Mark.3.28-30
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.12.31-32
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Heb.6.4-6
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Heb.10.29
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1John.5.16
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Num.15.30
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Mark.3.29
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Matt.12.32
syntax	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Num.15.30
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Heb.6.6
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1John.5.16
interlinear	SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no	Mark.3.28-30

License audit

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Flags

complicating-unresolved · cross-tradition-divergent